

78 Free flowing goodness

Exciting HD media players tested this month. Sit back and enjoy!

84 Desktop PCs

Promising desktops from well known brands tested this month. Take your pick from this month's test

Feature



Twenty minutes is more than enough for 99 per cent of the programs you'd ever watch, but every now and then, with soccer finals going into extra time, it's better to have more of a buffer. However, the higher this setting, the lower the total number of programs you can record. I recommend that you set this to 5 minutes, and to ensure that you record special events fully, just record the next program as well – works well for me.

If there's one particular function of Tata Sky+ that's given me nightmares, it's the Series Link function. The theory's simple. If you like a particular program, Series Link it, and it's automatically recorded every time it's aired. However, with Tata Sky+, sometimes the option just automatically appears, but most times it's just impossible to find.

With Airtel, this option is easily accessible, and easy to set, but in

no way can I say that Airtel has got this right. For example, I series linked Friends, and when I tried to change the channel to watch some sports, it promptly told me I could not, because two channels were already being recorded – Zee Café and WB. “When did I tell it to record WB?” I thought. Flicking over to WB I found my answer. Airtel was trying to record all programs called “Friends” on all channels. Hardly what I'd call a satisfactory solution, but still a lot better than my Tata Sky+ experience.

Favourites

Although this is a feature that's not really limited to only the DVR boxes, I have to mention the implementation of Airtel's Favourites feature. Whilst Tata Sky offers up to 20 channels to be set as favourites, Airtel has four sets of 15 favourites each. This is well thought out, because consid-

ering the average family to have four people, this means that each of the four can set their favourites. However, as I mentioned before, you have to go through a few more clicks to get there in Airtel than in

Tata Sky, which has a dedicated button that directly takes you to the first channel in your Favourites list. One additional feature that Airtel offers here is Most Viewed, which lists the channels you've spent most of your time watching. Clearly, Airtel wins in this regard.

Not that it happens very often, but if you want to reset your favourites list, Tata Sky users will find this easier, as it has a delete all favourites function – while Airtel needs you to de-select each channel individually from the long list of channels in the guide.

Other cool stuff

Apart from all of the above, both service providers come with some really cool features that you should know about. Airtel launched with a feature called Mobile Recording, which allows you to download a little app to your mobile that will let you instruct your STB to

record a program, from literally anywhere in the world! Now this was a really cool feature that set Airtel's offering apart, but as I was typing this article out, Tata Sky announced that by end of April, all subscribers to its DVR service will be able to instruct their STBs to record any program from their mobiles, or any internet connected devices. Ah, the joys of being a consumer in a hotly contested market!

Another feature that's emerging is Video on Demand services, which thus far consisted of you watching movies that are played at certain time slots, for a fee. Now, thanks to competition kicking in, we will be able to get movies, documentaries and episodes of popular serials, anytime we want them.

One Airtel-only feature is Widgets. You get cricket updates, stock reports, weather in your city, and more, all displayed in a small box on your screen. What this does is, for example, help you keep track of a cricket score while watching another program, without ever changing the channel.

Decisions, decisions

The bottom line of this article is supposed to help you decide which to buy. Honestly, if you're subscribing to one of these providers already, there's no real value in switching. Like the mobile provider wars, this segment is all set to get crowded, which will mean more features, more entertainment, and at cheaper prices. The battle's only just beginning.

If you arm-twisted me into making a decision, I'd have to choose Airtel, but only because Tata Sky's response, although announced, hasn't been implemented yet, and as it stands at the end of April 2010, Airtel's digital TV Recorder offers more features for hardly anything more in terms of price. **A**

At a glance		
	Airtel digital TV Recorder	Tata Sky+
Price		
	For new subscribers	Rs. 6,990
	For existing subscribers	Rs. 6,990 + Rs. 1,000 credited to account
Hard drive capacity, recording hrs	160 GB, 100 hours	160 GB, ~100 hours
Connectors	HDMI, Component, SPDIF, Ethernet, Audio/video out, 2 x USB	Component, SPDIF, Ethernet, Audio/video out, 2 x USB
Positives	Feature packed	Easy to use interface
	Mobile recording	Fast channel surfing
	Easy to series link	Easy to set and delete favourites
	15 x 4 favourites	Soon to offer Mobile and Internet activated recording, true video on demand
	HDMI output	
Negatives	STB hangs occasionally, and	Series linking feature works erratically
	Widgets don't work sometimes	Lacks features
	Series link records from multiple channels	Only 20 favourites
	Interface needs more clicks	No HDMI
	Channel surfing is slow	